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Tiny arms stretch out for alms at swanky KNK Road

At the pedestrianised Khader Nawaz Khan Road in Nungambakkam, begging is rampant, and alms-seeking bowls are being carried not just by adults but children. How can you ensure government agencies put these children on the path to education and a better future?

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

Price tags inaccessible for a majority, Khader Nawaz Khan Road seemed designed solely for feet encased in a Miu Miu, a Polo Ralph Lauren and the like. That sentence is obviously hyperbole designed for effect. The point to be taken is the road is not just about high-street shopping experiences anymore. After pedestrianisation was walked into the picture, the price tags continued to smile only on select wallets, but the road began to sport a welcoming ear-to-ear grin for everyone.

KNK Road has become a hangout for everyone, not just the haves with a capital H. Aesthetically designed wide walkways doused in decorative lighting impart to the space an Instagrammable appeal: and that automatically opens the floodgates of Gen Zs still in college who subsist on a measly pocket money and Insta-clicks.

Budget-friendly slip-on chappals are at ease striding down KNK Road. And feet with visibly worn-out footwear and with no footwear also traipse in; but these feet often go disturbingly with hands that are stretched out for alms. The contrast between opulence and dire need can be missed anywhere else in Chennai, but not at KNK Road.

Through the day, mendicants can be seen moving along this road, approaching those who can offer them RBI-blessed paper (Indian currency, that is). When someone capable of parting with a 'hallowed paper' or two is spotted, they are relentlessly followed, the beseeching tone kept persistent.



Looking for alms at KNK Road. Though this picture shows an adult, children also beg at the Pedestrian Plaza.
PHOTO: LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

On a few occasions, this reporter has noticed these mendicants declining food and insisting on cash.

John Mathew, a regular at the KNK Road Pedestrian Plaza, observes: "Most of the mendicants refuse food despite incessant offers, instead insist on cash". Even GPay is good enough, Mathew adds with a chuckle, having GPaid a small sum once for a mendicant here. Another visitor notes that they throw away any food given to them, suggesting the preference for cash over food is a well-entrenched attitude among these mendicants.

Speaking from her experience, Joanne .N says they shadow their "target", refusing to take no for an answer; they are dogged in the pursuit of people they assume would part with some cash, following them for long distances. "It can get intimidating," adds Joanne.

Children with begging bowls

Mendicants have as much right to the pedestrianised space at KNK Road as anybody else. But what is disturbing is the shoe size of some of those feet. Small children frequently accompany the adults seeking alms and seek alms alongside those adults. Under the scorching sun, they walk on crowded pavements, extending their tiny hands toward strangers, seeking money. Their presence transforms what might initially be dismissed as a public inconvenience into a serious social concern that requires thought and intervention.

The issue of begging is neither new nor simple. It has existed forever, fostered by migration, poverty, lack of opportunities and systemic socio-economic fault lines. There is also a psychological side to begging: deadbeats, people who have given up the fight, stopped trying to work for their sustenance. However, what is common should not be equated with what is normal. Repeated occurrences should not normalise a problem, making society immune to it. There are systems in place to address this particular problem, systems that could be ineffectual and flabby for want of regular exercise. Rather than extending some succour to the outstretched arms, those systems should be challenged to offer the lasting solutions they promise. Effort should be taken to find out what could be keeping these children on the streets seeking alms. Children belong in schools, not on streets, earning their daily bread with a begging bowl.

Help should be sought. That begs the question: where?

Call child helpline 1098.

Call Chennai District Child Protection Unit – North at 6369124017; Chennai District Child Protection Unit – South is located in Alandur; and Chennai District Child Protection Unit – Central in T. Nagar. There is also support for begging adults, offered by a network of NGOs and government agencies.

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Tensile roofs for private vehicles?

The swanky roofs at this Ekkattuthangal bus stop have ended up supporting unauthorised parking

L.KANTHIMATHI

Greater Chennai Corporation has installed tensile roofs for bus shelters at Ekkattuthangal bus stops on 100 Feet Jawaharlal Nehru Main Road.

Here buses toward Guindy, Velachery, Tambaram, and Thiruvannamiyur halt. And at the opposite stop, buses toward Koyambedu,

Madhavaram, Red Hills, Thiru Vi Ka Nagar, Avadi, and Thiruverkadu halt.

While welcoming these roofs, regular commuters point out that at the stops for buses towards Koyambedu the tensile roofs seem to be serving owners of private vehicles more than bus commuters. Private vehicles are parked under the tensile roofs.

Parking of private vehicles at



The Ekkattuthangal bus stop meant for buses toward Koyambedu; and (below) the one meant for buses toward Guindy. Photos: VELANKANNI RAJ B & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

these bus stops is now new.

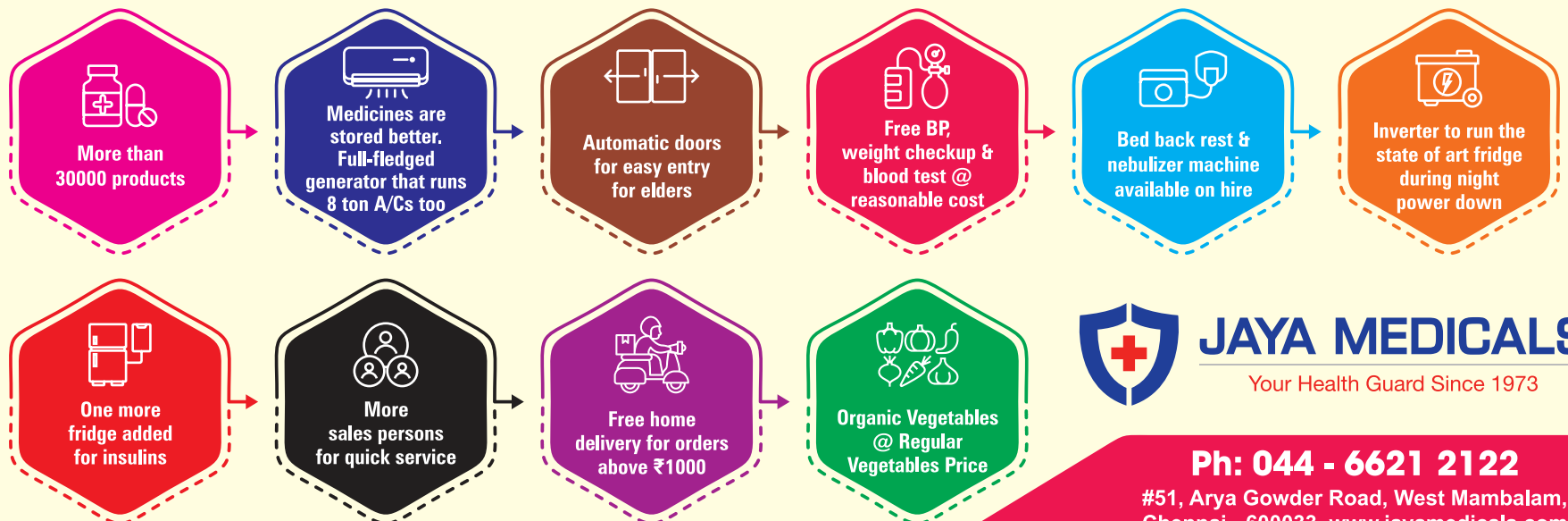
Commuters can be seen waiting near the main thoroughfare. This road witnesses heavy traffic and commuters are at the risk of being hit by vehicles.

Without addressing this problem, tensile roofs have been provided, say commuters.

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Renovation work under way at the facility.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Virugamabakkam crematorium receiving a facelift

Greater Chennai Corporation is carrying out renovation of the crematorium at Thangal Erikarai Street in Metukuppam, Virugamabakkam. According to officials, the work is being carried out at a cost of ₹1.34 crore, the capital fund of GCC.

A verdant landscape including a Miyawaki forest, sprawling lawns, new walkway, and a fresh coat of paint are some of the highlights of the project. The cremation ground falls under Ward 128 in Zone 10 - Kodambakkam.



SWD work at P.T. Rajan Salai



The work site on May 21, 2026.

A stormwater drain construction is under way at P.T. Rajan Salai in K.K. Nagar. According to Greater Chennai Corporation officials, the total length of the drain is 925 metres and the work is being carried out at a cost of ₹4 crore.

The drain connects Panner Selvam Road and MGR Canal on Anna Main Road. The work began this March and is expected to get completed in two months, say officials.

‘Pedestrian safety is compromised’

V. JOHAN DHANAKUMAR

The two-kilometre-long flyover connecting CIT Nagar First Main Road with South Usman Road, which was inaugurated in September last year, has considerably decongested the road.

The facility has certainly brought about a positive change.

However, pedestrian safety is compromised on the service road under the flyover.

Several vehicles including MTC buses roll down the service road.

But the footpath is marked by parking of vehicles.

It may be noted the service road is quite narrow and there is continuous traffic flow.

Pedestrians find it quite unsafe. The authorities should ensure the footpaths serve their intended purpose.

V. Johan Dhanakumar is a resident of Choolaimedu

The service under the flyover in T. Nagar.

PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



‘Facilitate a digital clock for the visually challenged’

P. SATHYANARAYANAN

Southern Railway should have a digital clock announcement system at the Guindy railway station footbridge to benefit the visually challenged.

People can be seen asking the public for the time, and this facility will help them plan and start their journey to their destination earlier.

Apart from this, at present, Southern Railway has put up signboards for platforms 1 and 2 at the foot overbridge, but they are not helpful to commuters.

The commuters, who are relatively new to the terminal, ask their counterparts which platforms to head to for boarding the electric trains towards Chennai Beach, Tambaram, Chengalpattu and Thirumalpur.

The announcements can be made through the system, or the platform number can be denoted on the tickets.

P. Sathyanarayanan is a senior social activist and a long-time resident of Guindy



Guindy railway station. FILE PHOTO



You can be our volunteer writer

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number

A teacher's legacy: from classrooms to canopies

Today, as she retires from service, biology teacher V. Kalaiselvi counts among her achievements a sense of stewardship towards nature particularly trees she instilled in her students. Here is a living testament to this attitude: robust trees at a neighbourhood in Maduravoyal that she helped plant 15 years ago directing a group of NSS volunteers from The Hindu Theological Higher Secondary School in Sowcarpet

School for 18 years, and in the last two years, at WPA Soundarapandiyar Higher Secondary School in Ayanavaran on compulsory deployment). As she bows out of service, one believes, the saplings she helped plant, and which are now strapping big trees, at Chokkanathan Nagar in Maduravoyal will sway in appreciation.

What was an effort lasting days by NSS student volunteers from this school in Sowcarpet has translated into a gain that continues across years for residents, making summers more bearable and the locality more environmentally sustainable. D. Narasimhan, secretary of the RWA at Chokkanathan Nagar, points out that a majority of trees from that initiative are Indian beech tree (*Pongamia pinnata*).

“The main aim was to increase the oxygen supply and educate the future generation about the importance of nature and the need to protect it,” says Kalaiselvi, thrilled at the opportunity to recall and reconstruct the exercise from the ground up.

Funding and logistics demanded meticulous planning, notes Kalaiselvi, adding hands stretched out with generosity, and some of those belonged to the residents. A good amount went out from Kalaiselvi's purse.

From the word go, the exercise had one component going for it: collective community effort. Residents of the locality reportedly welcomed the students wholeheartedly and contributed to the initiative in various ways which included arranging food and ensuring an interactive and pleasant experience for the students. The collective contribution transformed the planting initiative into a source of inspiration. Kalaiselvi also acknowledges the contribution of then deputy mayor P. Benjamin, whose support helped the campaign handsomely.

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

V. Selvaraj, a resident of Chokkanathan Nagar in Maduravoyal and vice president of the enclave's residents welfare association, has a plea for Greater Chennai Corporation: “trim the trees, please!”. There is a sense of urgency in that polite but firm imperative and also an unstated pride. He has seen those trees in their “toddler” years, as defenceless saplings. Those days are only 15 years into the past, when a tree-planting campaign swept across Chokkanathan Nagar. It was powered by around 30 NSS students from The Hindu Theological Higher Secondary School in Sowcarpet under the guidance of the school's NSS officer V. Kalaiselvi and the headmastership of V. Selvaraj.

Planted by tender hands, the initiative has photosynthesised into a powerful statement about community service. And the reason to revisit this initiative now? May 31 marks Kalaiselvi's day of retirement. (She served as biology teacher at The Hindu Theological Higher Secondary



The main aim was to increase the oxygen supply and educate the future generation about the importance of nature and the need to protect it

V. KALAISELVI.

Kalaiselvi has been involved in several social service initiatives over the years, and she clubs this one among those marked by long-term social responsibility. Service of this kind does not bring immediate recognition, as the full extent of its impact is known only years later, and its benefits usually enjoyed only by following generations. “Duty is more important than recognition,” says Kalaiselvi, underlining her philosophy of meaningful service.

The once small saplings now provide shade, contribute to cleaner air, and continue to be proof of what sustained community efforts can achieve.

However, as the trees have grown larger over the years, a few branches have extended toward the power lines, raising a safety concern among residents. Hence the plea from Selvaraj to Greater Chennai Corporation to have the trees trimmed. Tree trimming is not just for people's safety, but for the trees' health as well: timely and scientific trimming can keep the trees from getting top-heavy. Therein lies an important lesson; planting trees is only the beginning of environmental stewardship. Preservation demands continual care, and the civic body's support in this area with its tree-trimming equipment cannot be replaced.



Clicks and flicks

R. RAGU

S. Singarayer pursues two professions which share an essential feature, both rely on sharp timing; and in almost every other respect, they are galaxies apart. He has become a past master at switching between these diverse skillsets, one requiring him to click the camera button, and the other flick the Silambam stick.

A freelance events photographer, Singarayer had settled into a comfort zone, the photography assignments and payments steady and regular enough for him to want to break out of it and explore new ground. But here he is, teaching two batches of Silambam enthusiasts, one class being conducted in Villivakkam and the other at RBI Quarters in Kilpauk. And so, what got 49-year-old Singarayer here?

Before that question is answered, a quick bio of a younger Singarayer.

He entered the world letting out a shrill cry in Thiruvavur, where he grew up, along the way getting introduced to Silambam at school. He would go on to earn a B.Com degree at an arts college in Kumbakonam, and also qualify in printing technology, a course that helped him develop design skills. Career aspirations brought him to Chennai in 2000, and photography was nowhere in sight in those early years, but computers were. He had worked as a systems services technician at Ritchie Street off Mount Road for around three years when his primary calling came into sharp focus. A career in photography began, one that continues to this day.

A photographer revisits a childhood passion which has led him to the avocation of teaching Silambam to enthusiasts. Currently, he runs two batches in Chennai

He worked at the Konica outlet at Wallajah Road in Chepauk for 15 years, primarily working with photography software, framing pictures, restoring old photos and creating albums. And then he decided to strike out on his own, camera in hand: a long run as events photographer began.

Answering the question, he managed to circle back to his childhood passion, Silambam, through his daughter S.S. Sharoni. While ac-

companying Sharoni to Silambam classes, Singarayer would watch the training sessions from the sidelines. Gradually, he began brushing up on his old skills wielding the Silambam staff.

K. Shankar (aged 53), the Silambam master coaching Sharoni became coach to Singarayer too. An MTC bus driver having found a space to practise Silambam in his leisure time, Shankar was at the same wavelength as Singarayer.



Silambam masters S. Singarayer and K. Shankar with students at Villivakkam. PHOTOS. RAGU

Learn folk arts

Government College Of Fine Arts in Egmore offers four courses in folk arts, silambam being one. These are not regular programmes but conducted during the weekend and come under Folk Art Centre, an initiative being promoted by the government at select colleges in the state.

Each college offers some folk art examples being thappattam, paraattam and karagattam, largely based on the kind of enquiries they get. According to the principal, there is no age criteria to enrol in these programmes and the idea is to give people an opportunity to pursue hobbies with a cultural underpinning.

For details, call 044 - 25610878

Having noticed Singarayer's command over the Silambam staff, he encouraged him to pursue the martial art seriously.

The encouragement went further. Impressed by Singarayer's handling of Silambam techniques, the master eventually entrusted him with a batch of students of his own.

For the last three years, Singarayer has been conducting Silambam classes regularly. Assisting him in training sessions is Sharoni herself, now 14 years old and studying in Class IX. She has already won several medals at district-level competitions.

Singarayer offers Silambam coaching at a nominal fee of ₹500 per month; and to those who cannot afford that, he offers it free.

Determined to deepen his understanding of the martial art, Singarayer recently completed a one-year certification course in Silambam offered by the Tamil Nadu Government's Department of Art and Culture at the Government College of Fine Arts in Egmore.

For details, call Rajammal Silambam Boxing Sports Academy at 9841887183



Rare insights and photos of Kanchi Mahaswami

Chennai-based non-profit launches a book dedicated to Kanchi Mahaswami's spiritual walk



Sri Siva Vishnu Charitable Trust recently launched a new book titled "En Nenju Niraaya Puginthaar: Sri Kanchi Mahaperiyavaalum Ekambaramaagiya Naanum (Part 2)" at an event held at Sri Thyaga Bhrama Gana Sabha, T. Nagar.

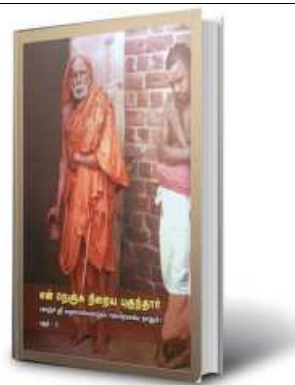
Authored by Ekamba-

ram, a close confidant who dedicated his life to the service (kainkaryam) of the Sage of Kanchi, the book offers an intimate, first hand account of one of the most spiritually significant journeys of the 20th century, said a release.

The book focuses on the padayatra (spiritual walk-

ing pilgrimage) undertaken by Sri Kanchi Mahaswami Sri Chandrasekarendra Saraswathi Swamigal- the revered 68th pontiff of the Sri Kanchi Kamakoti Peetam.

Between 1978 and 1984, Mahaswami traversed 3,860 kilometres over six years, walking from Kanchipuram to Satara. As a



During the launch. PHOTO. RAGU R THE HINDU

constant companion on this gruelling journey, Sri. Ekambaram meticulously chronicles unseen moments, moving accounts of the Mahaswami camping in remote villages and towns, blessing thousands of seekers along the way, and a curated collection of rare, historical photographs taken during the padayatra, added the release.

The copies of the book were presented to Mani Dravid Shastri, Mahamahopadhyaya and Professor, Chennai Sanskrit College; K. Jayaramakrishnan, industry expert, K. Chandrasekaran, advocate, Chennai High Court, Thiruvavur; N.

TANKER Foundation founder trustee meets Dalai Lama



Amid many cases of kidney disease and kidney failure among underprivileged communities in McLeod Gunj and surrounding regions, Georgi Abraham, Founder Trustee of TANKER Foundation, met Tibetan spiritual leader and Nobel Peace Laureate Dalai Lama on May 23, 2026.

According to a press release, the conversation focused on the work carried out by TANKER foundation in providing free dialysis treatment, conducting awareness programmes and screening camps for early detection and prevention, and supporting research related to renal health.

During the interaction, Dr Abraham said that TANKER foundation would extend support in establishing a dialysis centre in the region which aims to provide free and subsidised dialysis treatment for patients.

TN Nature Food Producers Federation meets Governor

Senthilkumar Maruthamuthu, state coordinator of the Tamil Nadu Nature Food Producers Federation and Chairman of Cholanadu Farmers Producers Company Ltd, called on Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar at Raj Bhavan recently. Senthilkumar presented a brief on the agro-ecological transforma-

tions led by the Federation, with a special focus on the Cauvery Delta. He highlighted how modern IT enterprise workflows are being synchronised with ancient Tamil wisdom to drive rural prosperity, scale native seed conservation and protect regional biodiversity, said a release.



WOW Cricket League ends on a high



At the tournament event. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

RVS College of Arts and Science served as the title sponsor of WOW Cricket League (WCL) Season 2.

The tournament, organised by WOW HR at the Jeppiaar Engineering College ground, drew enthusiastic participation from the corporate community.

K. Senthil Ganesh, managing trustee of RVS Educational Institutions, inaugurated the tournament. The tournament featured nine

corporate teams competing in 12 exciting matches, culminating in the crowning of a champion team.

According to a press release, the tournament served as a vibrant platform for networking, team building, and development of meaningful business relationships. WCL is designed to promote employee engagement and corporate networking through the unifying spirit of sports, added the release.

Entrepreneurial skill training in solar energy

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute is conducting a training programme on entrepreneurial skills necessary in the solar energy sector. It will be held from June 3 to 12. According to a press release, the programme will focus on basics of solar energy, solar components and system design. The session will also cover concepts of marketing, pricing, and legal procedures.

The institute is also conducting another workshop on baking from June 2 to 5. According to a press release, the session will focus of making baked products from millets, heirloom rice varieties, and wheat. This includes: cakes, breads, biscuits, cookies, and pizzas. Participants will also learn about packing, labelling and pricing of the products.

Prior registration is necessary to take part in the sessions. The workshops will be held at the institute's premises at EDII Office Road, SIDCO Industrial Estate, Guindy. For details, call 8668102600 / 78069 18309.

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The death of this Green sea turtle near Akkarai beach a few days ago should serve as a reminder of what we can do to make the Chennai coast truly home for the sea turtles, particularly the Olive Ridley turtles

PRINCE FREDERICK

Here are the details of a recent event by the southern coast of Chennai. A few days ago, Captain A. Ranganathan, a compelling voice in aviation circles and a resident of Injambakkam on the sea-side, chanced by a Green sea turtle that was dead to everything around it. The sad sighting happened on the sands between Akkarai beach and Injambakkam beach. Every event has a lesson: some lessons might not be actionable. What is the lesson, actionable or otherwise, to take away from this?

As a hatchling, this green sea turtle would have dodged a cartel of pelagic predators. As an adult, it would have survived attacks by apex marine predators. All of that for what? Only to be done in by a ridiculous piece of nylon. That is irony of an order where pathos and farcicality exist side by side.

Net loss



A dead Green sea turtle near Akkarai beach.
PHOTO: CAPTAIN A. RANGANATHAN

An inference: danger is often most potent where it is least suspected. A seemingly innocuous civic infra work on the road outside your gates does not get your antennas up;

and you get impaled on steel rods jutting out of an open trench. A fishing net does not get your flippers twitch with anxiety; and you get entangled and find a tragic end. While

that inference could be right, it puts an undue burden on the victim, letting the perpetrator off the hook. Where danger is not expected but hidden and real, those alive to the possibility should take preventive action.

This topic is hardly new: what can be done in the coastal waters to protect sea turtles?

Arun V., coordinator of Students Sea Turtle Conservation Network notes that from the government side, considerable efforts have been taken, largely by way of patrolling to check illegal fishing methods that can result in death of sea turtles.

Despite that, the deaths continue. "Sea turtle deaths in the last two years (actually last two seasons) have been alarming. In relative terms, the deaths have been low in 2026, but that does mean much when you compare it against the huge numbers in 2025."

When Arun is talking about the season, he is essentially talking about the Olive Ridley nesting along the Chennai coast, the nesting happening from January to March, and the hatchlings leaving for the seas in April.

"We do not get Green sea turtles often but Olive Ridley turtles getting entangled in fishing nets is way too common," says Arun. "Those the maximum traffic is around the season, those three to four months of the year, turtle movement is found throughout the year."

Arun notes that one measure, which ought to be definitely taken during the Olive Ridley turtle hatchling season is to avoid laying out the

fishing nets in the waters at night, as it is only at night these turtles come ashore to lay eggs. The possibility of entanglement in nets laid in the coastal waters is high at night during the nesting season. During a recent interaction with fishermen from Nainar Kuppam, this reporter was presented with many cases of how fishermen disentangled sea turtles from fishing nets and eased them back into the waters, safely. Fishing communities along the coast revere sea turtles attaching metaphysical significance to them.

"There is never wanton killing; it is always accidental," says Arun.

The SSTCN coordinator observes that sustainable fishing practices would be a blanket solution, but set against the question of livelihoods for fishing communities, they cannot be activated at will. The best bet would be educate fishing communities how to take certain steps, those factoring in the seasons to prevent turtle deaths from entanglement in nets and injuries from boats. Meanwhile, there are a few things residents of neighbourhoods along the Chennai coast could do for their part to help the cause. Arun lists them out: "Steer clear of misinformation: the biggest challenge this year came from wrong information put out on social media. As a result, many people were disturbing the nesting Olive Ridley turtles with bright lights right on their faces. Turtles abandoned nesting. What residents can do: avoid lights, littering and vehicles on beaches. Corporation should switch off mast lights during the hatchling season."

Making the right moves at

Meet coach and counsellor Ebenezer Joseph who recently won three gold medals in the 60+ category at the Commonwealth Chess Championships

K. KEERTHIVASAN

At 60, Ebenezer Joseph is a bundle of energy. He coaches children, trains teachers, competes in tournaments and also serves as counsellor for educational institutions, strongly advocating the inclusion of chess in school curricula.

Recently, the Anna Nagar resident, who works as an Audit Supervisor in the Indian Audit & Ac-

counts Department (IA & AD) at the Finance and Audit Office in Egmore, made headlines after winning three gold medals in the classical, rapid and blitz events in the 60+ category at the Commonwealth Chess Championships held in Kalutara, Sri Lanka.

Ebenezer was thrilled with the achievement, especially since he had only hoped to return with at least a bronze medal. "I expected to win one bronze medal, but to win three gold medals was unbelievable. Though I won in the 60+ category, I played in the Open sec-



Ebenezer Joseph (second from left) felicitated by Aadhav Arjuna, MLA, Villivakkam and other dignitaries

tion alongside top young Grandmasters such as P. Iniyar and S. Rohith Krishna, besides FIDE Master Sakline Mostafa Sajid, Candidate Master S. Sivathanujan and Woman Candidate Master Ananya Raman. It felt great," he said.

Speaking about the demands of competing in three formats, which often meant spending long hours at the board, Ebenezer said the tournament was physically and mentally exhausting. "The pressure was immense because on certain days we had to play as many as eight rounds.

My matches started at 4 p.m. and finished at 8 p.m., so much so that on the last day I hardly knew what was happening on the board!" he said with a smile.

Having spent more than 34 years with the Indian Audit & Accounts Department, Ebenezer felt the process of obtaining a No Objection Certificate (NOC) from employers to participate in international tournaments should be simplified. "When a player is representing the country, the process of getting an NOC from the employer to take part in an inter-

national event should be made easier," he said.

Ebenezer continues to balance his professional commitments with his passion for chess and social service. "I will continue playing, continue trying to help more sportspeople get recruited into Government offices and continue working with tribal communities," said the 60-year-old, who is also a Senior Lead Instructor for FIDE Chess in Education Commission and is set to retire from IA & AD in November this year.

60